

Course PC 731 Ethnography and Applications 3-0-0-3

Course Instructor - Vishvajit Pandya

Course Objectives :Contemporary Communication Design informed by multi-media technologies are meant to be immersive, engaging and meaningful experiences. The method of Ethnography which derives from the discipline of Anthropology teaches students to understand cultures, communication and social activities at large through, immersive exposure and participant-observation. This makes it particularly relevant to the discipline of Communication Design. Ethnographic analysis provides powerful tools to understand how communication practices, tools and systems inform and impact social relations and cultural practices.

Course Content :

The module introduces the foundations and basic methods of ethnography derived from the fields of *visual anthropology* and *social and cultural anthropology*. It will look at several applications of these disciplines to current communication practices. Students would be expected to undertake *fieldwork assignments* and related applied activities such as collection of *empirical data, qualitative data, contextual inquiry* and usability testing that provides the foundations for *user-experience design and visual design*. The objective of the module is to provide the student the intellectual tools to develop research capacity for the final design projects they would have to undertake.

Students will be also required to read and be prepared for in-class presentations and discussions of their readings and how these speak to their field experiences.

Evaluation

There will be continuous evaluation for this module, and include, in-class readings and presentations, field work and the writing and presentation of field reports and research papers.

Course outcome

At the end of the module, students will be able to acquire a deeper understanding of user-research beyond the usual field survey or AI driven analytics. They will deploy their ethnographic research insights to develop better user-profiles and journeys and therefore design more ethically, effectively and responsibly.